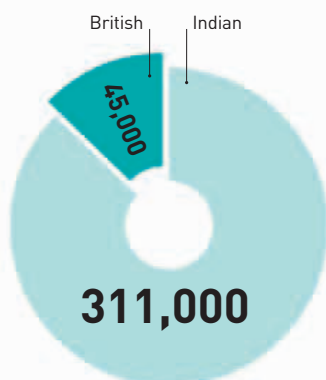




English painter Thomas Jones Barker's *The Relief of Lucknow* completed in 1859, depicts British forces defending this colonial city after the end of a prolonged siege during the Sepoy Rebellion.

IN 1857, A RUMOR SPREAD THROUGH THE INDIAN TROOPS—known as **sepoys**—in the Bengal Army stationed at Meerut, Northern India. Their new rifle cartridges were reputed to be greased with pork and beef fat. The cartridges were for a new type of rifle, the **Enfield**, and to load them the ends of the paper cartridges needed to be bitten off. For Hindu and Muslim soldiers, allowing beef or pork fat in their mouths went against their respective religions beliefs. Added to this rumor were various other grievances, together with a



British-Indian army in 1857

A much larger proportion of Indians than British served in the army, making an uprising involving the Indian troops a serious threat.

growing suspicion that the British were also trying to undermine Indian culture and traditions. The soldiers refused to use the cartridges, and the subsequent dispute that broke out between Indian troops and British commanders sparked the revolt known as the **Sepoy Rebellion** (also known as the **Indian Mutiny**).

The unrest lasted for more than a year, as the mutineers were joined by peasants angry at their exploitative landlords, as well as those who resented the recent British annexation of the north Indian region of Oudh. The rebels managed to capture Delhi and “restore” an aging Mughal emperor, **Bahadur Shah II** (1775–1862), to power, while killing the British in Delhi and the nearby cities of Kanpur and Lucknow. The retaliation by the British army was similarly brutal, and they recaptured Delhi in September and Lucknow the following March. The revolt was suppressed by June 1858.

This conflict was the culmination of frustration with the East India Company's rule as well as creeping **westernization** as Britain annexed more territories and sent out more officials. The uprising provoked deep concern in Britain, and the East India

“ A FREE NEGRO OF THE AFRICAN RACE... IS NOT A ‘CITIZEN’ WITHIN THE MEANING OF THE CONSTITUTION OF THE UNITED STATES. ”

Chief Justice Roger Taney in the *Dred Scott v. Sandford* case, April 1854



Dred Scott

A slave in the US, Dred Scott sued his owner for his freedom. The case went to the US Supreme Court, where his emancipation was denied.

Company was stripped of its power to control India. The Company by this point was hated throughout India, and the British government thought it could no longer be relied on to keep stability (see panel, 1858). The Mutiny had shown the level of Indian discontent and anger, which would continue to grow under British rule, while at the same time helping to fuel the independence movement.

In addition to the conflict in India, British troops had returned to battle in **China**. Britain demanded greater freedom of trade in China in the wake of the Treaty of Nanjing (see 1842), but the Chinese resisted. In 1856, the British sent an expedition with the French to attack China's ports, culminating in the **Second Opium War**.

Anglo-French forces attacked Canton in 1857. By the following year, the **Treaties of Tianjin** were negotiated between China, Britain, and France, as well as with Russia and the US. These agreements called for China to open more ports and to legalize opium importation. In addition, foreign diplomats were given the right to live in **Peking**. The Chinese refused to ratify these agreements until 1860.

In the US, the **abolitionist** cause suffered a serious setback when a Supreme Court ruling in the case *Dred Scott v. John F. A. Sandford* declared slavery to be **legal** in all US territories. The case was brought by **Dred Scott**. He was taken by his owner, John Emerson, from the slave state of Missouri (see 1820) to the “free” Wisconsin

territory, later returning to Missouri. Scott, with the aid of abolitionists, filed a lawsuit claiming the move from slave to free state had broken his chain of servitude. The case reached the Supreme Court in 1857, where the justices voted against freeing Scott on the grounds that he was not entitled to rights as a **US citizen**, including the right to sue in a court of law. The judges also declared the Missouri Compromise (see 1820) unconstitutional because Congress could not deprive citizens of their property. It was up to the states to decide to ban slavery, and there was nothing to stop new territories becoming slave states.



Enfield rifle and cartridges

The paper cartridges contained powder and a bullet. After removing the cartridge's end, the powder was poured out into the barrel. The cartridge and bullet were then rammed in.

paper cartridges containing powder and bullet

muzzle-loading barrel

